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ation. Wirk first met Sharma on the sets of the reality show *Knights and Angels* which she was styling for. "Anushka wanted to look her age and wear something fresh," says Wirk.

The safe and rather boring route of draping a sari to every event is now closed. The young raring-to-go Bollywoodians prefer the road that leads to edgy fashion. "Celebrities attend so many events today. They want to look different for each. If they continue to wear just one designer, they look the same," says Mumbai designer Gayatri Khanna, whose butterfly dress and tunic has been a hot favourite with Deepika Padukone. Young fashionistas also like the fact that the new designers are more European in their sensibilities.

Often labelled over-the-top, fashion in celebrityville is undergoing a huge change. Increasingly, bling is being shunned in favour of cleaner lines and drapes. "A lot of the young actors today have been models. They have travelled the world and follow international fashion trends. If rompers are in, they are not scared of wearing them," says Agarwal, who started his eponymous label just three years ago. Already designs have found fans in the 20-somethings. Genelia D'Souza wore a pink Agarwal gown to the IIFA awards, Chopra wore a short little orange number to the *Fashion* success party and Padukone wore a pink jumpsuit for a brand endorsement event. In fact, that same jumpsuit has become so popular after Padukone and models like Nina Manuel wore it that within eight months, Agarwal's sold at least a 100 pieces in different colours.

That, of course, is not always a good thing. Amrita Rao, trying very hard to break out of her *Vivah* image, has been repeatedly slipping into short numbers by Shinde. It came to a point that her appearances were all looking the same. Thankfully, another Shinde loyalist, Mugdha Godse, who met the designer while working as a model, hasn't fallen into that trap. Godse's stuck to the young couturiers but has chosen everyone from Khanna to Miguel to Shinde. "Young celebrities want clothes that spell easy chic.

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▲ Gavin MIGUEL 31

CELEB QUOTIENT

Priyanka Chopra (right), Mugdha Godse, Tabu

DRESS CODE

Flirty dresses and draped gowns

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CELEB QUOTIENT

Deepika Padukone (right), Genelia D'Souza

DRESS CODE

High on glamour and drama in solid colours



Newer designers offer that edgy and eclectic mix. Girls like Shriya Saran love clothes by Walnut," says Kanchan Dhingra, creative director of multi-brand store Chamomile.

But it's not always that celebrities dole out the cash for an outfit. Designers say that most times celebrities just ask for clothes and then return them after the event. Even when clothes are tailored for special events, most find their way back to the designer's studio. These end up on the racks of stores. No one minds this arrangement; least of all the designers. After all there couldn't be better publicity. "Stores used to take my clothes only on consignment basis but once they saw celebrities wearing my clothes, they started purchasing outright," says Shinde.

Not everyone is a fan of the designer-celebrity relationship. Fashion watchers don't tire of stressing that clothes were being edged out because of too much Bollywood. Showstoppers have after all become the bane of every fashion critic's existence. But designers agree that showstoppers were unnecessary and the hoopla lasts only for one evening. Even then it helps. The first time Agarwal had a showstopper in 2008, his business went up by 30 per cent. Celebrities wearing a designer's clothes make perfect sense. "People want to dress like them. If celebs wear our clothes, people will buy them," says Khanna. Bling is already on its way out, can fashion faux pas be next, please. ■